



Cedar Creek

Mark Twain National Forest · Missouri

1 night · 17 mi

2 nights · 34 mi

3 nights · 37 mi

Recommended · 2 nights · 4 hikers

Base camp at Rutherford Bridge

33.9^{mi}

● Easy to moderate (USFS)

● 2,825 ft gain

● Tap water at 2 stops

Backpacking, 3 days

Day 1 · Pine Ridge to the bridge, then Devil's Backbone **11.6 mi**

Day 2 · Moon Loop with day packs **13.2 mi**

Day 3 · Smith Creek north side, back to Pine Ridge **9.1 mi**

1 Pine Ridge Recreation Area

2 Nevins Homestead

3 Dry Fork Recreation Area

4 Overlook above Cedar Creek

5 Rutherford Bridge

6 Devil's Backbone

7 Moon Loop

8 Burnett School Road bridge

National Forest land, camping allowed

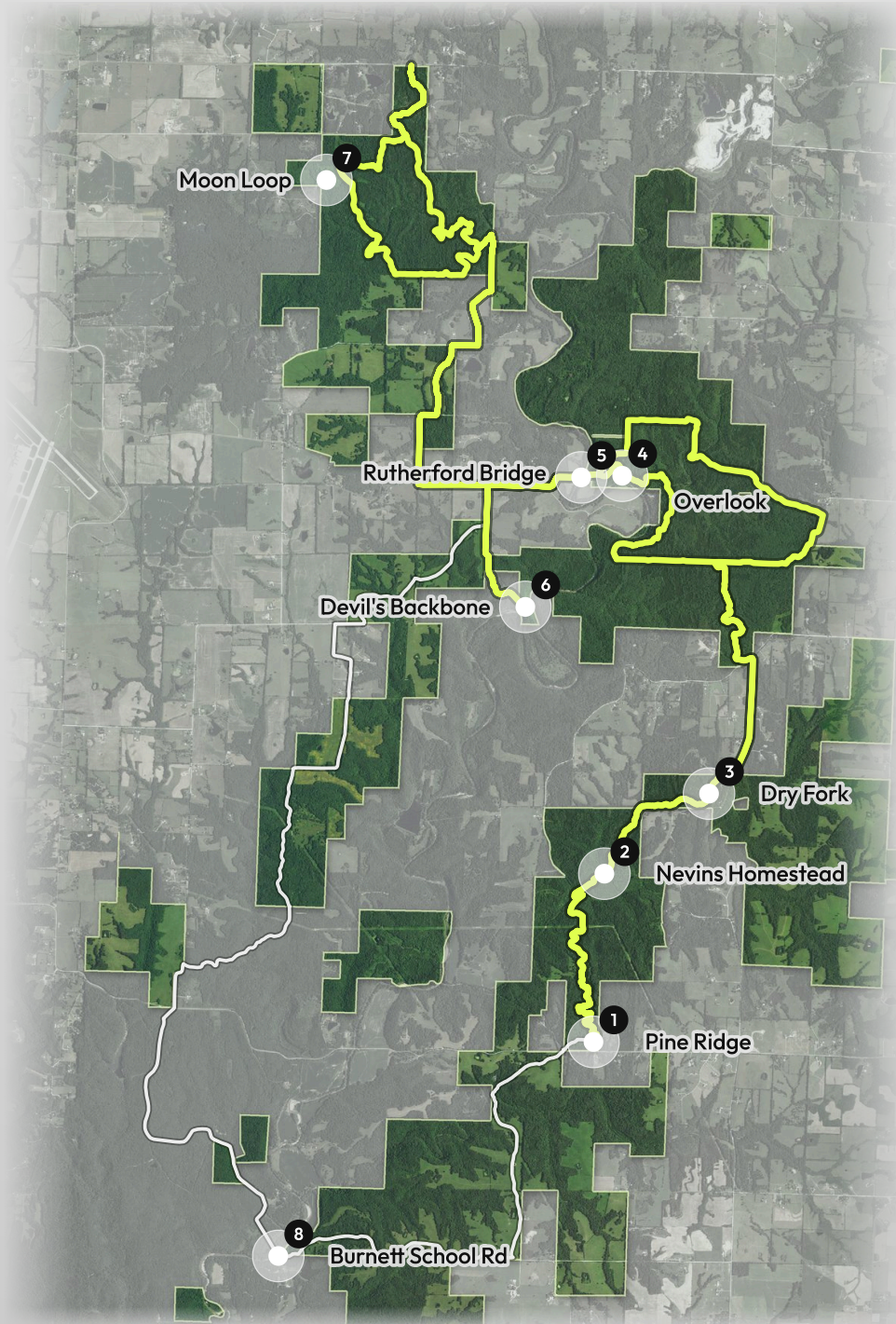
Private land, stay on the trail

Recommended route

Other routes in this plan

Park at Pine Ridge. Tap water only at Pine Ridge and Dry Fork. Every night is on Cedar Creek.

Prepared Oct 6, 2026



Pick the number of nights

Miles measured on OpenStreetMap trail data. Elevation from USGS 3DEP. Allow about 2 mph with packs, plus breaks.

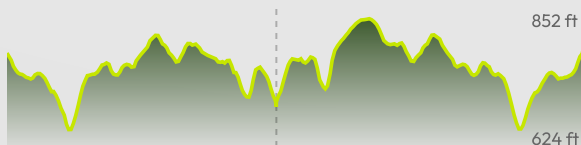
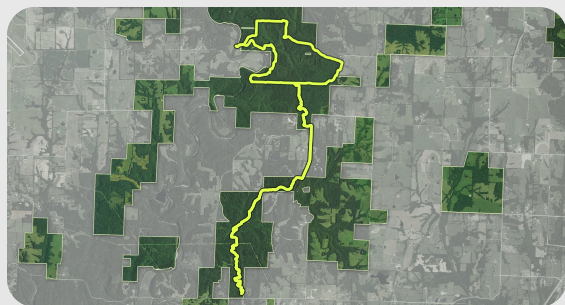
Cedar Creek Trail · 1 night

Smith Creek and Rutherford Bridge

17.1^{mi}

● Easy to moderate

● 1,628 ft gain



Day 1 8.0 Day 2 9.1

Day 1 Pine Ridge to Rutherford Bridge 8.0 mi 734 ft

Day 2 Rutherford Bridge to Pine Ridge 9.1 mi 894 ft

 Open the route on AllTrails

Cedar Creek Trail · 2 nights

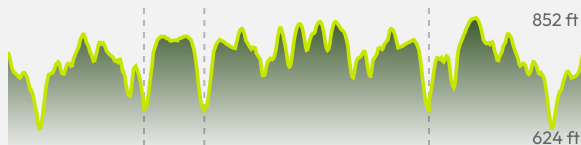
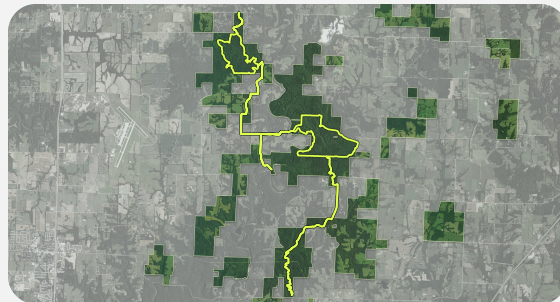
Base camp at Rutherford Bridge

Recommended

33.9^{mi}

● Easy to moderate

● 2,825 ft gain



Day 1 8.0 3.5 Day 2 13.2 Day 3 9.1

Day 1 Pine Ridge to Rutherford Bridge 8.0 mi 734 ft

Day 1 evening Devil's Backbone side trip 3.5 mi 195 ft

Day 2 Moon Loop with day packs 13.2 mi 1,002 ft

Day 3 Rutherford Bridge to Pine Ridge 9.1 mi 894 ft

 Open the route on AllTrails

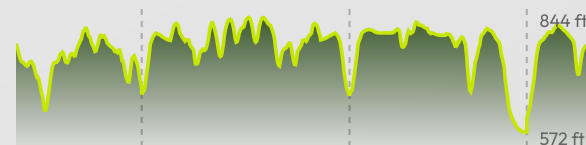
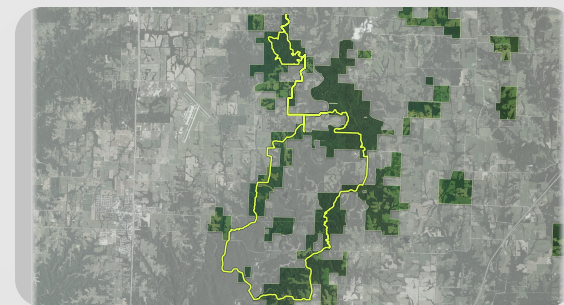
Cedar Creek Trail · 3 nights

The whole trail system

36.7^{mi}

● Easy to moderate

● 2,854 ft gain



Day 1 8.0 Day 2 13.2 Day 3 11.3 4.1

Day 1 Pine Ridge to Rutherford Bridge 8.0 mi 734 ft

Day 2 Moon Loop with day packs 13.2 mi 1,002 ft

Day 3 Rutherford Bridge to Burnett School Rd bridge 11.3 mi 718 ft

Day 4 Burnett School Rd bridge to Pine Ridge 4.1 mi 400 ft

 Open the route on AllTrails

Milestones

1 Pine Ridge Recreation Area
Start and finish. Drinking water, a vault toilet and 8 campsites at \$15 a night, first come first served.

3 Dry Fork Recreation Area
The last tap water, at 3.3 mi. Fill every bottle here.

5 Rutherford Bridge
An iron road bridge more than 100 years old, now a footbridge over Cedar Creek. Base camp, 8.0 mi in.

7 Moon Loop
Land so eroded in the 1930s that it looked like the moon, now restored. Best trail markers on the system.

2 Nevins Homestead
An old cabin on the trail, 2.1 mi from Pine Ridge. The position is from the USFS map, not a GPS point.

4 Overlook above Cedar Creek
Bluffs 100 to 150 ft above the creek, with cedars on the edge. 0.3 mi east of Rutherford Bridge.

6 Devil's Backbone
A narrow ridge cut by erosion on both sides, 1.8 mi past the bridge. The last half mile is on Backbone Road.

8 Burnett School Road bridge
Cedar Creek crossing on the 3-night route. University of Missouri land is next to it, so check the boundary before you camp.

Waterfalls: none on this route. The nearest candidate is Rock Bridge in Rock Bridge Memorial State Park, near Columbia. It is classed as a "waterfall natural bridge", so it is a maybe for the drive home.

Before you go

 **Water**
On Oct 4, 2026 a hiker reported every Moon Loop creek crossing dry. Cedar Creek usually runs. Bring a filter and a pre-filter, or leave a water cache at Rutherford Bridge by car.

 **Ticks**
Clouds of seed ticks on Moon Loop in August 2026. None on Oct 4. Treat clothes with permethrin.

 **Cattle**
Some fields have cattle until mid-October. Close every gate behind you.

 **Mud and high water**
Horses use the trail. Reviews from May to July 2026 report deep mud, and one hiker turned back at a high Smith Creek. Do not go after heavy rain.

 **Hunting**
Youth firearms Oct 24 to 25 and firearms deer season Nov 14 to 24, 2026 (MDC). Archery runs all fall. Wear blaze orange.

 **Navigation**
Reports range from poorly marked to very well marked. Download the routes to every phone before you go.

* Emergency

Callaway County 911

Callaway Community Hospital (573) 642-3376

Ranger district, weekdays 8:00 to 4:30 (417) 967-4194